



Neurodiversity in the Classroom

A guide for creating inclusive, strengths-based learning environments that support all students.

Why is neurodiversity education and awareness important?

Younger children are more likely to exclude, judge, and be uncensored about their thoughts on different behaviors, creating stigmas that last a lifetime. Providing such education helps prevent psychological harm to neurodivergent students and gives students an understanding of neurodiversity that will hopefully carry through their entire lives.

Key Vocabulary

Neurodiversity: A term that references the diversity of human minds. This is a term for the biological fact that each person's mind is different from any other mind.

- **Neurodiverse:** (NOT neurodivergent) Describes a group of people with diverse brains. Ex: Humans are a neurodiverse species.

Neurodivergent: An adjective to describe a person whose brain functions differently from what is considered typical (e.g., autism, dyslexia, etc)

Note: This is a very abbreviated set of important vocabulary. A complete list is linked at the bottom of this page.

Legal Accommodations and Diagnoses

Students with a documented condition qualify for accommodations through a 504 plan or an IEP. Common classroom accommodations might include:

- Flexible seating options
- Extended time on classwork, homework, tests, and quizzes.
- Chunking large assignments into smaller tasks
- visual schedules and checklist(s)
- Alternative ways to demonstrate learning, depending on the student's needs and preferences.

Supporting Neurodivergent Learners

Proven by clinical experts and the Child Mind organization.

Three fundamental areas where neurodivergent students tend to need help are behavioral issues, social challenges, and executive functioning. When a student is acting out in some way, it typically means they're struggling in one of these areas. The best way to alleviate these feelings is typically to validate their feelings: give students a chance to explain how they feel, why they did what they did, and let them know you hear them. By leading this into brainstorming and problem-solving, a teacher not only gives them time to calm down, but teaches them how to deal with similar future situations. Some examples of good supports for all three fundamental areas include:

- Having a relaxation area
- Giving students a safe person to approach for help
- Providing a clear visual, like a schedule, of each day
- Scheduling or allowing breaks during class time
- Reward Systems (stickers, star charts, etc.) for younger students
- Mentoring programs (afterschool, during lunch, before school, etc.)
- Praising students for overall inclusivity
- Peer support groups
- Open lines of communication (talk to parents & the students about severe concerns)

Key Principles in Supporting a Neurodiverse Classroom:

Universal Learning Discipline (UDL)

UDL is a teaching framework that asks teachers to plan for differences in learners before a lesson happens, rather than making accommodations afterward.

Essentially, this means offering more than one way to take in information (video, text, hands-on demo), more than one way for students to show what they know (writing, speaking, building, drawing), and more than one way to stay motivated (choice, relevance, varied levels of challenge)

Strength Based Model

The strength-based model is an approach to working with students that starts by identifying what a student is good at, interested in, and motivated by. It uses those as the foundation for teaching, rather than starting from a list of problems to fix.

Various research on the strength-based model has found that when teachers focus on student strengths, engagement rises, relationships improve, and academic outcomes strengthen, particularly for neurodivergent learners. (Elmbridge University)

Further Resources

- For comprehensive vocabulary explanations: <https://neuroqueer.com/neurodiversity-terms-and-definitions/>
- A guide to neurodiversity affirming terminology: <https://ndconnection.co.uk/resources/p/nd-affirming-language-guide>
- Further and more comprehensive information on fostering a neurodivergent-friendly classroom: <https://www.schoolcounselor.org/Newsletters/March-2024/Support-Neurodivergent-Students>



Lesson Plan Guidance

The following pages are guides and notes for implementing the lesson plans.

Cocoon Corner's Neurodiversity Curriculum:

Curriculum Framework

Day 1: Neurodiversity concept: *"Neurodiversity means that all our brains are different."*

- This is perhaps the most important message in neurodiversity advocacy– deceptively simple, but by dedicating the first day to understanding it, we give kids this foundational base knowledge to build off of for the rest of the week
- There are a lot of fun games that demonstrate this concept: would-you-rather, drawing games– this should be an engaging kick-off to the week!

Day 2: Accommodations (& neurodivergence): *"What I need is different from what my classmates need"*

- The kids should leave the classroom understanding the difference between fairness and equality.
- Depending on the grade level, kids might go on to apply that in the classroom. This serves to introduce accommodations in a way that reduces stigma and "that's unfair!"-ness.

Day 3: Communication: *"People have different ways of communicating that they find easier and harder for them."*

- Difficulty with peer-to-peer communication is a pretty prominent issue for many neurodivergent students (particularly autistic kids).
- This day is focused on introducing the "double empathy problem", a psychological theory stating that communication breakdowns between autistic and non-autistic people are a two-way mutual issue. Day three's curriculum also demonstrates to kids that there are many valid methods of communication, and it's important to "meet in the middle" when people have different methods.
- The depth in which classes explore this topic (like all previous days) is dependent on grade level.

Day 4: Applying concepts from days 1-3 in real life: *"How can I apply what I've learned in my day-to-day life?"*

- This day is focused on synthesizing all the new information that kids have learned in the past few days and learning how to apply all the concepts to real-life situations.
- For many grade levels, this involves groups students working through "situation cards" that incorporate themes of neurodiversity, neurodivergence, accommodations, and the double empathy problem in a situation familiar to that age group. Using what they've learned, they can brainstorm a resolution that is supportive to all brain types involved.

Day 5: Commitment to neurodiversity acceptance: *"How can I commit to accommodating and celebrating neurodiversity and neurodivergence going forward?"*

- Day five, the last day of our week of lesson plans, is dedicated to helping classrooms commit to incorporating neurodiversity acceptance & celebration in their communities
- A lot of classrooms already have "class norms" or rules set out at the beginning of the year. If desired, it may be effective to review these norms that might be gathering dust (What are we doing well with? What can we work on going forward?), and maybe add some new ones that cater to neurodiversity/neurodivergence acceptance.
- In upper grade levels, students will learn the concept of neurodivergence and common diagnoses.

After teaching Cocoon Corner's lesson plans, we would be incredibly grateful if instructors could take 3 minutes to fill out [our feedback form](#) so we can improve our curricula.

Tips for Implementation

- Please keep in mind that our activity timings are estimations and may vary across classrooms. Many lessons consist of an introduction to the daily topic and then two activities. If you're short on time, you can pick just one follow-up activity.
- Feel free to adjust our lessons for your class as needed: you can directly edit the lessons or replace activities with materials from other grades. The daily takeaways are the same across all grades, and you can find all activities on our website.
- We highly recommend that you read through the lesson plan before execution for a smooth delivery.

Grade K Teacher Guide

Day 1

- Reinforce core message throughout the lesson
- Neurodiversity includes many different conditions, including autism, ADHD, dyslexia, Tourette syndrome, etc.
- Use inclusive language
- Avoid words like 'normal' or 'abnormal'
- Every brain works differently

Day 2

- Explain that fairness doesn't mean everyone gets the same thing
- Avoid singling out kids when discussing accommodations
- validate students' perspectives
- Conclude that helping people get what they need allows everyone to learn and have fun together

Day 3

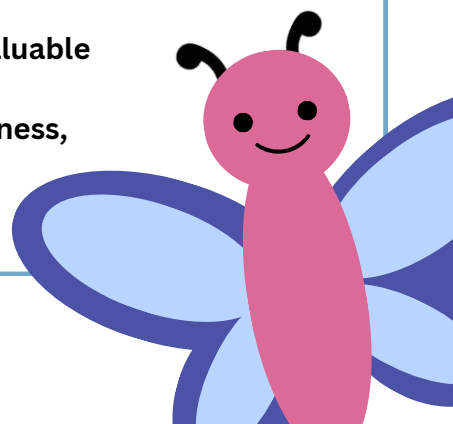
- Greet all students with different greetings
- Help students express their thoughts and expressions in different ways
- There are lots of ways to be kind, so let students try them with each other

Day 4

- Review neurodiversity, fairness, and communication
- Recognize that people express emotions and respond to situations in different ways
- Encourage respect and inclusion
- Different does not mean wrong, and kindness and inclusion help everyone feel welcome.

Day 5

- During reflection activity, acknowledge every student's drawing as valuable
- Praise inclusive behavior if it happens
- Keep using the vocabulary from the lesson plans (neurodiversity, fairness, communication, kindness, etc.)



Grade 1 Teacher Guide

Day 1

- Prevent peer influence during Would You Rather activity
- Focus discussion on *why* choices were made
- Provide simple and easy examples for brain activity
- Prompt students with simple questions if they say “I don’t know”
- E.g. “What makes you smile?”

Day 2

- Video: play the video for students and call on kids for discussion questions.
- Discuss: conclude that each kid has different needs based on how many cookies they had to start with.
- Activity: Reinforce the idea that fair does not mean equal after scenario card discussion.

Day 3

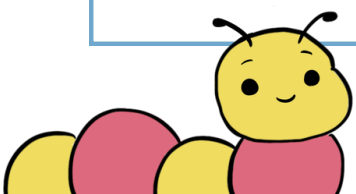
- Read the book aloud to students, along with showing them the picture as you read
- Ask about the students’ opinions on the book and how they can help when someone communicates differently
- Show how using precise language can help prevent confusion

Day 4

- When watching the video, pause every few minutes for questions so students can comprehend it more
- Let students discuss the questions in a group or aloud
- As students are sharing their thoughts and opinions, listen to them
- Motivate students to participate in the shareout

Day 5

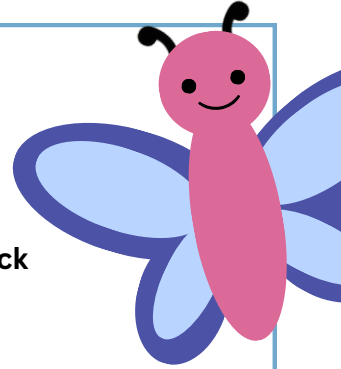
- Give a short review on inclusivity, fairness, respect, and communication, then ask kids to suggest classroom guidelines and write them on the board.
- Worksheet: Pass out worksheets and give students ideas about what to make their Hexagon about during activity into.



Grade 2 Teacher Guide

Day 1

- Preview the video and stop at 1:10
- Don't treat the popular answer as the normal answer
- Remind students to be curious and not judgmental
- Use drawings from "Draw Your Perfect Classroom" as useful student feedback



Day 2

- Play this video and ask discussion questions. Steer kids toward answers about needing different glasses because not everyone is born with the same eyesight.
- Demonstration: pass out discussion cards first, then proceed with the demonstration.
- Conclude and discuss: distinguish between equal vs fair, explain in the context of each scenario.

Day 3

- Ask the student what fairness meant to them
- Play the video and ask discussion questions: Is it equality or equity
- Encourage students to participate in the demonstration activity so they can comprehend the differences between the two

Day 4

- Play the video first fully, then a second time, but pause every few minutes to ask students questions to hear their thoughts and opinions about what's happening in the movie
- Ask students to share their answer aloud if they're comfortable

Day 5

- Assign groups for the Inclusion Jigsaw
- This prevents students from getting left out
- Allow drawing as an alternative to writing
- Review notes before reading them aloud; make sure they do not contain any negative information
- Keep the Kindness Jar going throughout all the lesson plans

Grade 3-5 Teacher Guide

Day 1

- Explain each part of the word “neurodiversity”. Explain how differences in the way people’s brain works is beautiful and encourages creativity and growth.
- For grade 3: Pass out the worksheet and have students discuss results at the end. How are they different?
- For grade 4 and 5: have students explain their own experiences with percieving the world differently

Day 2

- Play the video and have students discuss. Emphasize the difference between equity and equality.
- For activities, lead students through discussion. Conclude by reflecting that when everyone gets the same treatment, that sometimes can lead to negative consequences, because they not everyone has the same chance to learn and experience things.

Day 3

- allow students to be creative and think of ways to greet someone without using words
- Read the scenario and discuss how to show your friend that you love them
- Show and explain to students different ways to communicate nonverbally

Day 4

- For the Louis’ Shoes activity, stray away from ideas that want to change Louis, rather than ideas that remove barriers
- Encourage evidence-based responses
- Ask students how their impressions changed from the beginning of the film to the end
- Avoid portraying empathy as pity

Day 5

- Keep the pledge focused on classroom culture
- Grades 3-5 are ready for more accurate vocabulary and deeper concepts
- Discourage students from diagnosing themselves or classmates
- If a question gets too personal or directed at someone, redirect the conversation back to the general discussion

